from Rajiv Gandhi onwards that Indian leaders truly understood the dynamics of global economics. India's leaders now are well aware of the rise of China – which has built its international stature by enhancing its economic power.

According to Mansingh, India tried initially to achieve economic self-reliance by seeking three goals: concessional development assistance, diversification of trading partners and changing the international economic order.[23] The first would help India follow its own independent policies without being accountable to others. This tied into both non-alignment as well as the desire to avoid being part of any system or bloc. India sought aid from international organizations like the World Bank, International Monetary Fund (IMF) and even from the Aid India Consortium, viewing them as multilateral donors offering assistance with no strings attached.

By having several trading partners, India wanted to make sure that it had its eggs in many baskets and was not dependent on just one buyer or supplier. The belief that the international system was skewed in favour of the superpowers and discriminated against developing countries like India led to the desire to change the world order. India has frequently called for a new international economic order, for reform of the IMF and the World Bank and even for reform of the UN Security Council.

The Nehruvian approach to economics as well as economic diplomacy did not serve India well. Sumit Ganguly and Manjeet Pardesi point out that, 'The failure to develop ties with the global economy contributed to a paucity of foreign investment, important technological lags, a lack of innovation, and the stifling of entrepreneurship. In turn, these forces contributed to what the eminent Indian economist Raj Krishna mordantly referred to as the "Hindu rate of growth".'[24]

Immediately after Independence, the emphasis on economic autarky or self-sufficiency made it a concern of domestic, not foreign, policy. Self-reliance was seen as critical to ensuring India's independence and even now